VML

2025 Predictions for Search Marketing

How you can prepare for changes ahead in the search landscape

3 Major Search Evolutions

01

Google's search **dominance is under threat.**

02

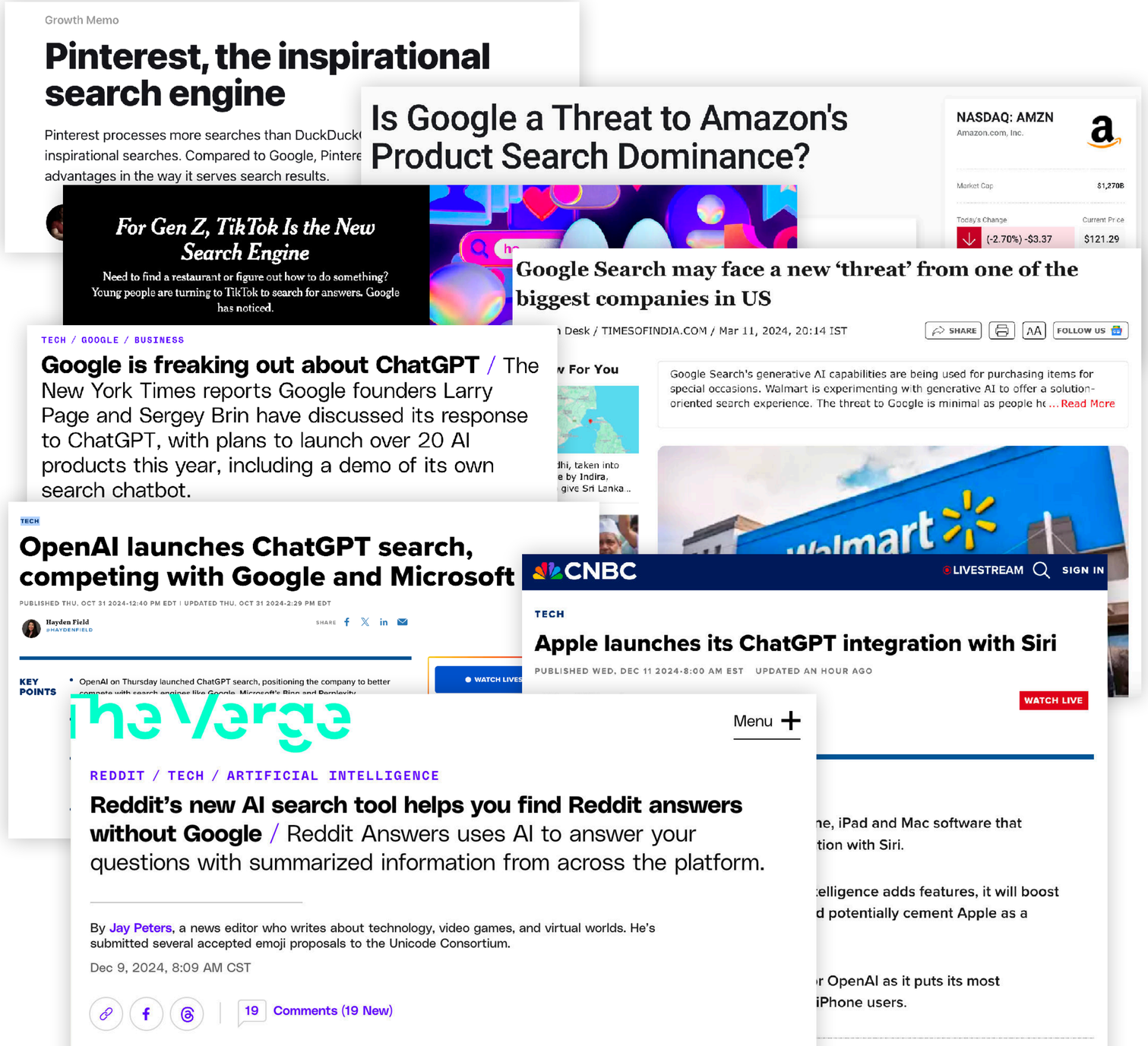
AI is **reshaping the search landscape.**

03

Measuring search success is changing.

Google Under Threat

More platforms than ever are claiming to be search engines or to have advanced search capabilities, putting Google's dominance at risk for the first time in 15 years. This means a more diverse and fragmented landscape for searchers to find what they need — and new ways for brands to be discovered when customers search.



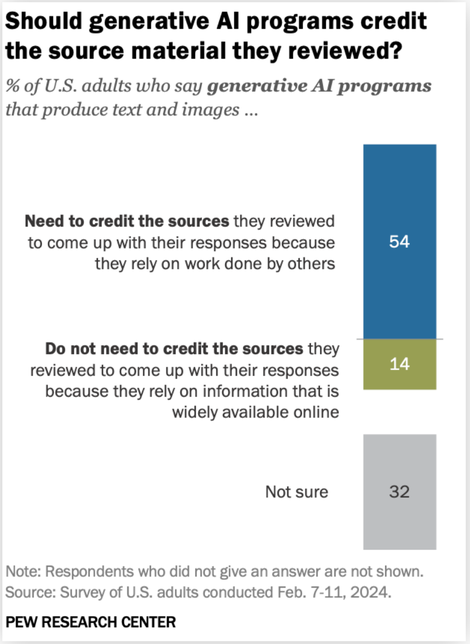
AI Changes Everything for Search

Artificial intelligence and large language models are changing where and how people search. From new applications of AI technologies to augment search work to platforms evolving how they deliver search results to customers' changing expectations when they search, the search landscape is reshaping in real time.

A survey of more than 11,000 Americans found that more than half (55%) regularly interact with AI

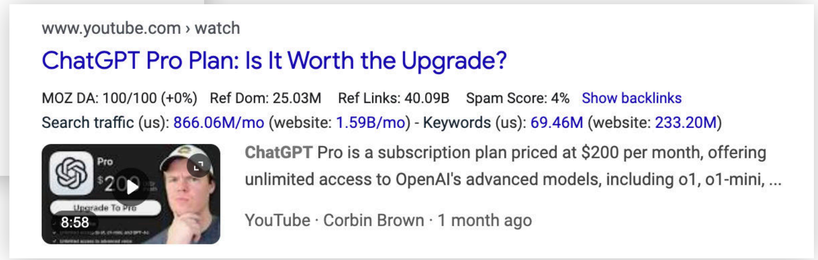
27% report several times a day

While users lean more on AI, there are still questions of trust in the sources that users interact with.



Consumer expectations around AI search models are increasing as well as the competition for engagement.

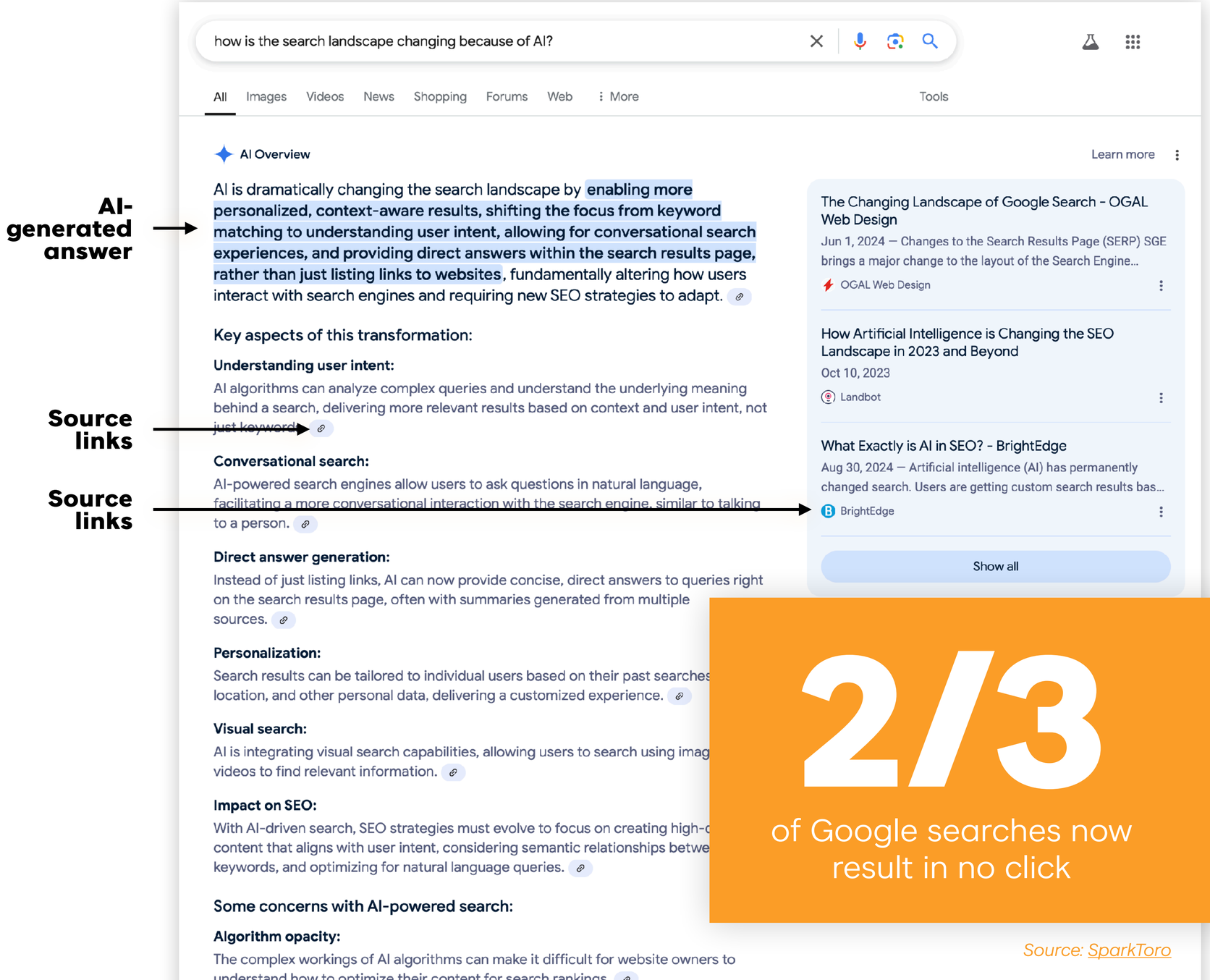




Sources: Pew Research Center, Tech Radar

Search Success Will Look Different

Evolving search experiences and technologies mean an increase in “zero-click searches,” where searchers get more immediate, synthesized answers. Traditional rankings and traffic measurements will become dated, and marketers need to reevaluate the key performance indicators of search success.

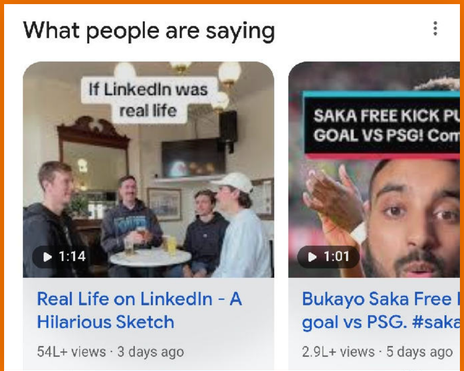


2/3

of Google searches now result in no click

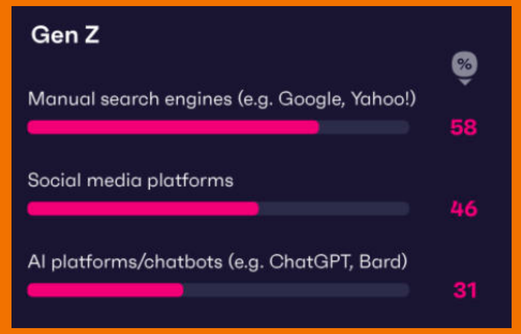
Source: SparkToro

What are the top predictions for search in 2025?



The boundaries between digital platforms will blur even more when people search.

AI-driven search results are expanding content opportunities even more across channels. Google is showing us that eventually all available channels will be scraped and integrated into search results as much as possible.



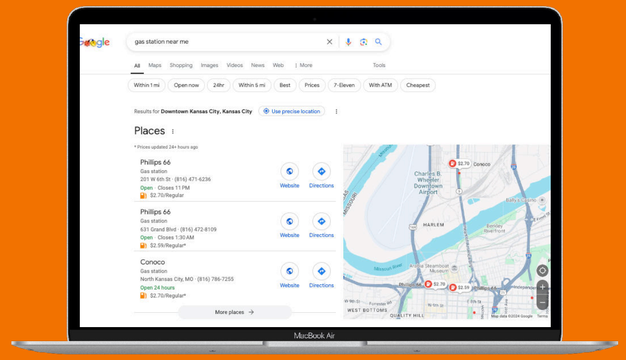
AI models will permanently change how people search and what they expect.

AI is entering a more realistic phase of growth, moving past the hype to focus on practical, tangible benefits. By understanding its current limits and strengths, we can integrate AI strategically to drive meaningful results.



AI will enable all-new multimedia ad formats to deliver in searchable spaces.

Google AI is showing the accessibility of AI-driven ad campaigns that deliver the right ad format to the right person at the right time to reach our campaign goals.



Local listings are grabbing more search real estate and engagement.

Google's local pack is taking up more real estate and pushing organic brand results further down on the SERP, impacting visibility and click-through rates. This shift gives ideal positioning on the SERP to local businesses.

What are the most important developments in search across key industries?



Ecommerce and Retail

The walled gardens of data will continue the fragmentation problem in commerce search.



Travel and Tourism

The tourism industry will face new challenges — and opportunities — as AI search helps travelers plan their journeys.



Automotive

Automotive brands will double down on vehicle voice search assistance potential.

1.0

Search Predictions for 2025

The boundaries between digital platforms will blur even more when people search.

The Scoop

AI-driven search results are expanding content opportunities even more across channels. Google is showing us that eventually all available channels will be scraped and integrated into search results as much as possible.

- Search engine result pages continue to evolve from text links to more visual, interactive experiences. Emphasizing the importance of multiple content types and adapting to this new paradigm of search.
- AI-generated results are delivering more information in real time, like game scores and weather/ news alerts at the top of results.

Updates That Are Indicators of Future Search Result Evolution:

- **AI-Generated Results From Multiple Sources:**
  - Google has morphed the "What people are saying" section of search results to feature forum sites, like Reddit. Now, Google is testing this but with short videos on TikTok and other platforms.
  - Google said in its testing that searchers "have found AI-organized search results pages more helpful. And with AI-organized search results pages, we're bringing people more diverse content formats and sites, creating even more opportunities for content to be discovered."
- **Google Leaning Into Visual Search:** Google Photos has morphed from being a fairly basic photo organizer to an AI-powered memory bank with the "Ask Photos" feature.

What It Means for You

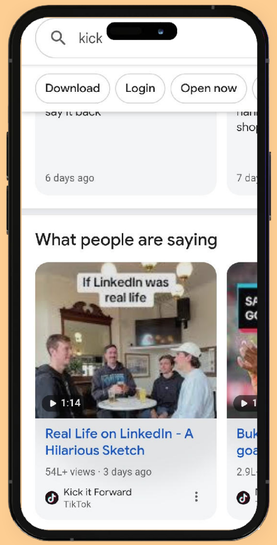
- **Anticipate what channels you have in your ecosystem that might be integrated into search.** Evaluate outdated content and assets to ensure the information search engines scrape and serve are accurate.
- **Track AI overviews for performance indicators** on AI-generated search results for Google search.
- **Use site analytics to track traffic from emerging search engines and chatbots** and find possible correlations in user behavior.

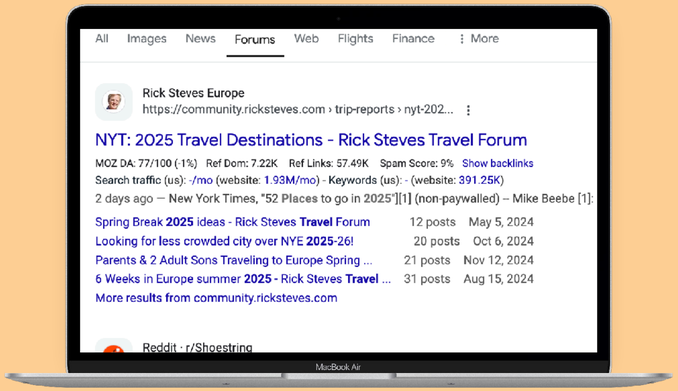
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Sources: Google, Ipsos, Online Video Ads Pre-testing Database, Global 2021-2024, Pew Research Center

Searchers Are Increasingly Seeing Content From Other Platforms Appear in Search Results

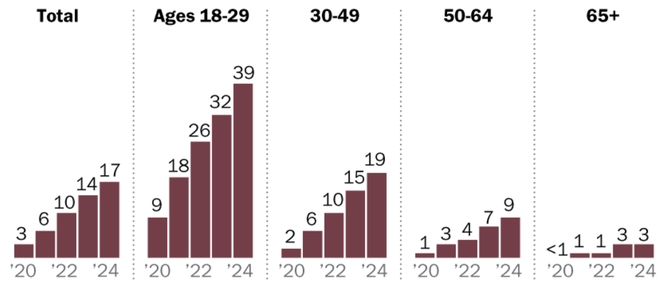
Search engines are returning content from the platforms.





About 4 in 10 young adults in the U.S. now regularly get news on TikTok

*% of U.S. adults who **regularly** get news from TikTok, by age group*



Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted July 15-Aug. 4, 2024.

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They Are Also Leaning on Nontraditional Search Platforms in New Ways

Platforms are positioning themselves as search engines.

The share of adults who say they regularly get news from TikTok has grown about fivefold, from 3% in 2020 to 17% in 2024.

AI models will permanently change how people search and what they expect.

The Scoop

AI has evolved beyond the flashy headlines to become a transformative force. By leveraging AI intelligently, we can align with clients to unlock new opportunities for growth in an ever-changing digital landscape.

- **Incremental shift in search patterns** — Previous search patterns are evolving as users interact with AI-powered search results and voice assistants on phones and other devices (*see right graph*).
- **Paradigm shift** — Users are leveraging AI for more conversational versus keyword-based queries and multifaceted, multistep directives in a single search to produce more complex and conditional results.
- **More competition in the field** — The field of search is growing as competitors like Perplexity, ChatGPT, and even Apple, Hulu, Walmart, etc., are tapping into experiences that use search functionalities.
  - Ex: Amazon's Rufus gathers information from product listings and across the web to answer shopper's questions in merchant platforms. Retailers are imitating to improve page retention.
- **Rise in voice search** — Voice search could experience a resurgence as AI-enhanced voice assistants drive more conversational and user-friendly interactions, making it a preferred method for some journeys.

What It Means for You

AI is entering a more realistic phase of growth, moving past the hype to focus on practical, tangible benefits. By understanding its current limits and strengths, we can integrate AI strategically to drive meaningful results.

- **AI cannot be ignored** — While AI knowledge was a "nice to have/optional," it is increasingly becoming a necessity to master as entire jobs/roles are adapting to this new technology.
- **AI will not replace humans anytime soon** — This technology requires human creativity and context to perform as intended. AI lacks context and real-world information, which is where we shine. "AI Won't Replace Humans — But Humans With AI Will Replace Humans Without AI" — *Karim R. Lakhani, Harvard Business School Professor*
- **Evolving with AI** — To scale with AI, we must embrace automation, refine strategies, audit workflows, and integrate AI-driven insights, ensuring clear and efficient processes for seamless integration and continuous improvement.
- **User intent will be more important than ever** — This shift highlights the need to understand user intent, whether for personalized local searches or broader, context-driven queries.

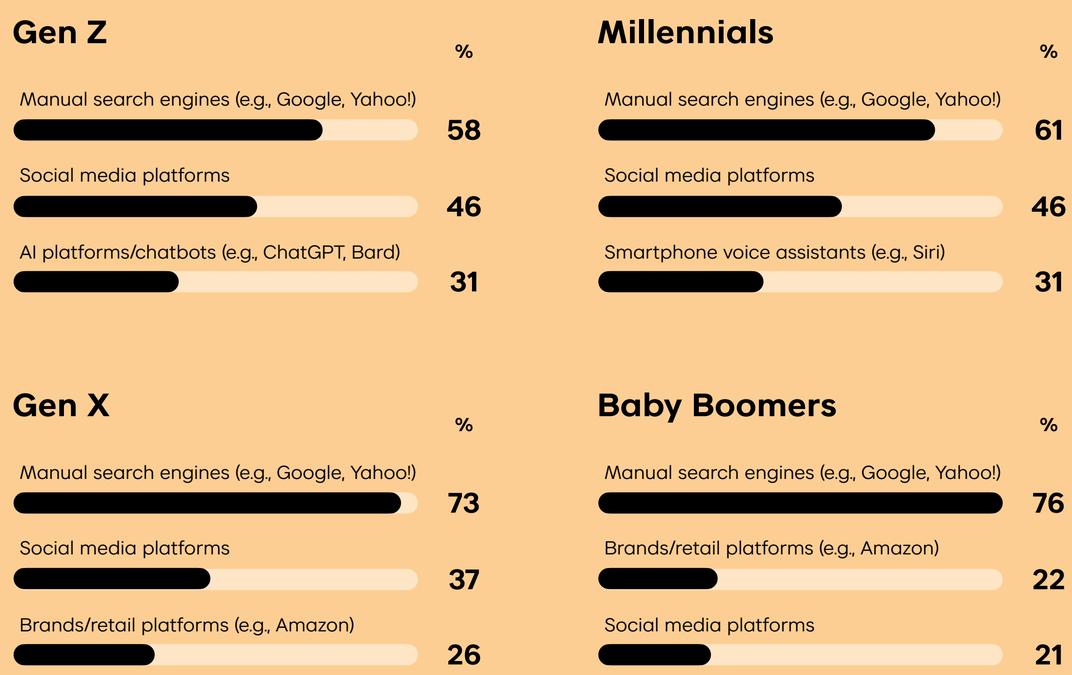
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Sources: Graph (GWI)

AI in search: Charting changing trends in search engines

How search habits vary by generation

% in each generation who say they most use the following to find information on the internet (top 3)



***Question**: Which of these platforms/places do you use most to find information on the internet?*

GWI Zeitgeist August 2023 *15,469 internet users in 12 markets aged 16-64*

Source: Global Web Index

AI will enable all-new multimedia ad formats to deliver in searchable spaces.

The Scoop

Consumers are evaluating more brands and products, and competition for their attention has grown across more media channels than ever before. Video consumption has exploded on YouTube across formats and screens. Google AI is showing the accessibility of AI-driven ad campaigns that deliver the right ad format to the right person at the right time to reach our campaign goals.

- YouTube is the only multiformat platform where audiences tune in to watch more of your ad view time versus other digital platforms under similar testing conditions.
- With the emergence of AI, advertisers can utilize new YouTube AI-powered mixed-format solutions that combine multiple ad formats within a single campaign.
- Google AI powers 40% more views at a 30% lower Cost Per Views.
- Short-form video ads taking center stage, a mix of professional and user-generated-type content. YouTube Shorts is Google's response to the TikTok and Meta's Reels phenomenon.

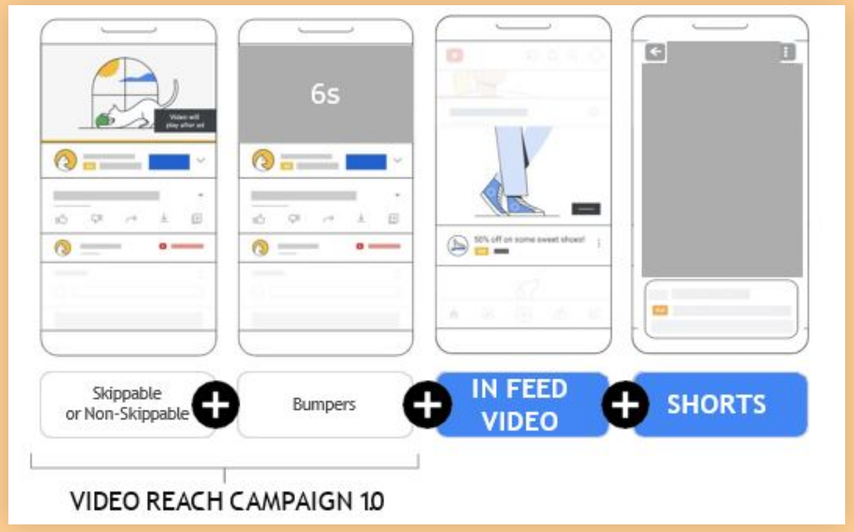
What It Means for You

Leverage Google AI to find the format optimal mix for more views, reach, and purchase consideration with multiformat video campaigns and lower costs on average compared to in-stream CPV alone. This will set a new expectation for how marketers use AI to relay their brands across paid and organic touch points.

- **Using Google AI, YouTube can accurately predict users that will return** to the platform with over 95% success in frequency goals.
- Through the use of Google AI, one-third of consumers are now spending more time evaluating their purchase decisions, while 40% are open to switching brands for better value. This has led to a threefold **increase in the likelihood of purchase consideration.**



The next evolution of multiple inventory formats to maximize reach.



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Sources: Google, Ipsos, Online Video Ads Pre-testing Database, Global 2021-2024

Local listings are grabbing more search real estate and engagement.

The Scoop

Google's local pack is taking up more real estate and pushing organic brand results further down on the SERP, impacting visibility and click-through rates. This shift gives ideal positioning on the SERP to local businesses.

- The **local pack's growth reduces the already limited above-the-fold space available** for organic results, especially on mobile. This makes it harder for businesses relying only on organic SEO to gain visibility.
- **The local pack is location-based and visually dominant, appearing above organic results**. It provides business information directly on the SERP, while organic results link to webpages. This allows users to interact directly with businesses outside of organic clicks.

What It Means for You

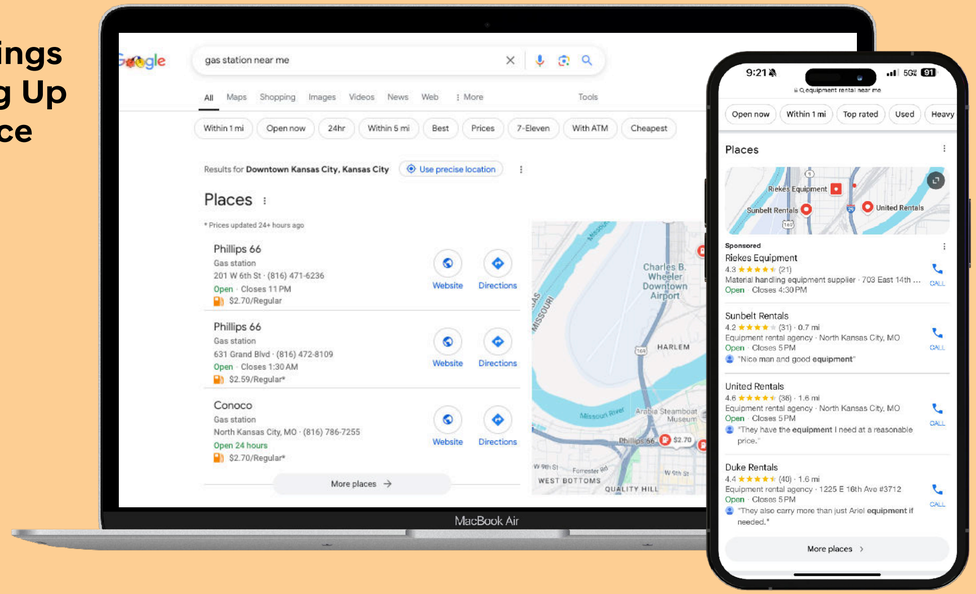
46% of all Google searches are local. This growing prominence of the local pack signifies a shift in how users discover businesses online. Understanding and adapting to this change by prioritizing local SEO and Google Business Profile optimizations is necessary for maintaining visibility and reaching target audiences.

- **Google's Ranking Factors.** Google uses relevance, distance and prominence to rank businesses in the local pack. It takes into account how well a business profile matches the search, how far away the search results are, how well known a business is and is based on information Google has about a business.
- **Improving Local Ranking**. Ongoing effort in managing and optimizing Google Business Profiles and websites is essential. Key factors include complete information (address, phone number, attributes), location verification, primary GBP category, imagery, hours, reviews and in-store products listed.

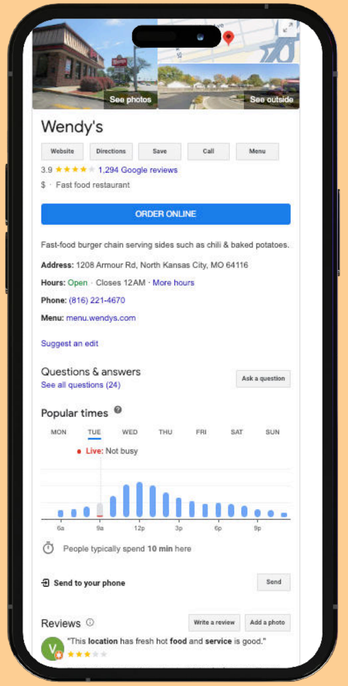
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Sources: Google, Forbes, SERanking, SEOdity

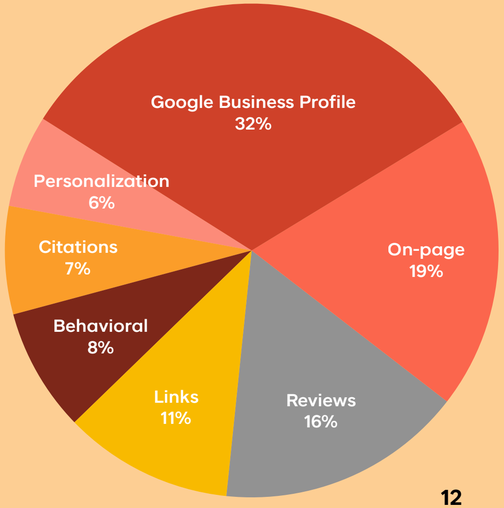
Local Listings Are Taking Up More Space in Search Results



Local Search Is Expanding Relevant Information



What Affects Local Search Visibility



Source: SearchLab, SEO CON

2.0

Industry Search Trends

The walled gardens of data will continue the fragmentation problem in commerce search.

The Scoop

Retailers continue building their own "walled gardens" of data — closed systems where they control how advertisers access and use consumer insights. This trend is most evident in retail media networks (RMNs), with Amazon and Walmart projected to capture 84% of all retail ad spending in 2025. However, the landscape continues to evolve, with smaller retailers following suit with their operations and launching their own ad platforms. For companies in the CPG industry, 2025 will continue to be a challenge as more retailers compete for advertiser investment, data becomes more fragmented and budgets are spread further across platforms.

What It Means for You

- **Strategic Challenges With More Choices**: As new retail media networks emerge, brands will face difficulties in fine-tuning their strategies and budgets to maximize effectiveness across multiple avenues.
- **Tailored Advertising on Each Platform**: Marketers will need to create ads that fit each platform's unique audience and data.
- **Focus on Measurable Results**: Advertisers will need to show clear returns on their ad spend, favoring platforms with high visibility and proven performance metrics.
- **Working Together on Data**: Stay tuned as brands and retailers continue to explore ways to share insights and collaborate to improve and obtain a fuller picture of performance.

Retail Media Networks Are Fighting Over a Small Slice of the Pie

% of U.S. retail media digital ad spending, by company, 2025



"Note: only select US companies with retail media networks shown; examples of retail media networks include Amazon's DSP and Etsy's Offsite Ads; includes ads purchased through retail media networks that may not appear on ecommerce sites or apps; digital ad spending includes advertising that appears on desktop and laptop computers as well as mobile phones, tablets, and other internet-connected devices, and includes all the various formats of advertising on those platforms."

Source: *eMarketer Forecast, Nov 2024*

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Sources: Digital Commerce 360, Martech, eMarketer

The tourism industry will face new challenges — and opportunities — as AI search helps travelers plan their journeys.

The Scoop

With the rise of AI, multiple brands are battling for audience interaction with AI tools and, thus, data.

AI is being integrated into all stages of the trip-planning calendar — planning, booking, staying and experiencing. Consumers are leveraging AI tools on their own to generate itineraries while also exploring the new trip planning tools that travel brands are developing to compete against the personalized recommendations that a travel agent might provide.

How Brands Are Looking To Capture the Search Interest of Travelers:

- Europe's largest air carrier, **Lufthansa, unveiled Swifty:** an AI assistant for business travel. Swifty focuses on speed, productivity and efficiency by helping business travelers book their trios in minutes via chat.
- American travel company **Expedia introduced Romie:** an AI assistant designed to serve as a booking agent, concierge and personal assistant all in one. Romie works by pulling information from user emails to build an itinerary.

What It Means for You

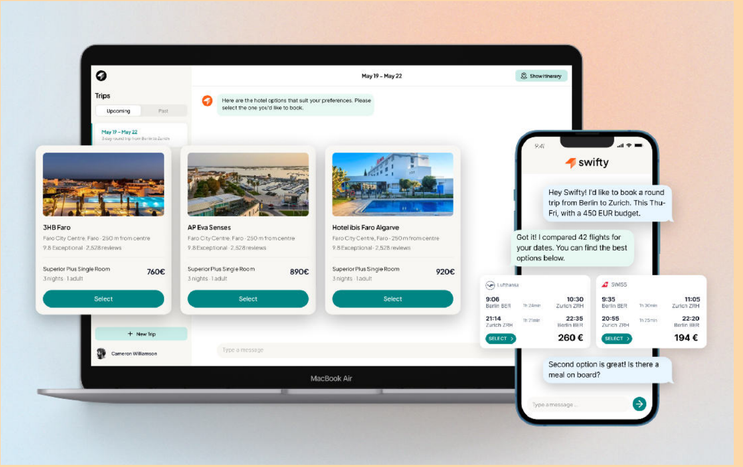
Tourism AI tools will face fragmentation as so many travel brands offer AI tools layering on existing search AI travel capabilities. With so many brands offering bespoke AI tools, consumers will choose what wins based on engagement and repeat use:

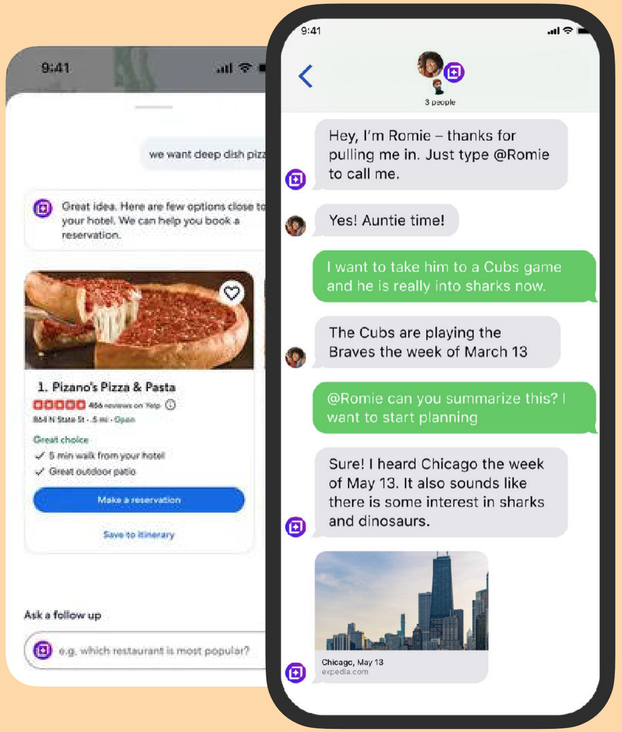
- As AI tools get more relevant via more personal user data, users will balance value of AI-generated results with concerns over the potential invasion of privacy. Marketing teams should be good stewards of user data and application for personalized experiences that don't feel intrusive.
- Ensure your site offers unique value before you look to build out AI-driven solutions that help tourists plan trips.
- Consider the platforms travelers are leaning the most on and seek ways to be discoverable instead of competing against behemoths like Google Flights. Consider all potential traveler phases and challenges to assist not only in the planning phase but also during a travel experience.

swifty

Lufthansa's Swifty:

Acts as a personal assistant for business travelers looking to correlate hotel and flight options quickly and efficiently.





Romie™

Expedia's Romie:

Leverages email data, relevant locations, and seasonality data for itinerary building before and during travel — for example, letting a traveler know an event is going to be rained out and offering alternate plans.

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Source: Lufthansa Group, Globetrender

Automotive brands will double down on vehicle voice search assistance potential.

The Scoop

AI has significantly become an area of interest for multiple business sectors. Automotive companies have already started integrating IoT and AI into their systems, and it is projected that they will be leveraged even further in 2025. The combination of voice assist technology and AI will prove to be a powerful tool for companies and appeal to growing audiences.

How Companies Are Leveraging Voice Assist Technology:

- Research from Statista shows that the **number of people using digital voice assistants has increased drastically in 2024**. Based on trend data, we can expect this growth to continue in 2025.
- **Mercedes and Volkswagen have started to integrate AI into their voice systems.** Following this early adoption trend, Rivian has also announced the launch of its AI-powered voice assist that will be arriving in 2025. Companies are leaning into AI-powered voice assists to offer users convenient and elevated ways to drive.
- **Volkswagen's IDA voice assistant has already made waves in the news** with its capabilities and offerings. IDA voice assistant is able to answer general knowledge questions and engage in natural, humanlike conversations. The integration of ChatGPT has allowed IDA to provide accurate and relevant responses to nearly every query imaginable, and provide a multitude of suggestions ensuring a transformative experience for the user.

What It Means for You:

AI voice assist technology has started to change the way users search. With several tools packaged neatly in one inclusive system, people have started to rely on them for information. As AI starts to get integrated into these systems, a plethora of online sources will be used to pull in best-in-class answers.

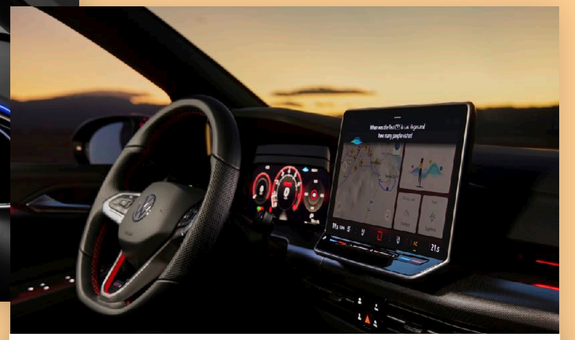
- **Ensure that your content targets conversational and question keywords**. Users that are engaging with voice assist systems use more natural language.
- **Track potential traffic from emerging voice assistants** to better understand user behavior when leveraging vehicle voice assistants.

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Sources: Auto Desk, eMarketer, Volkswagen, Edmunds, Medium, SEMrush, Mercedes, Statista

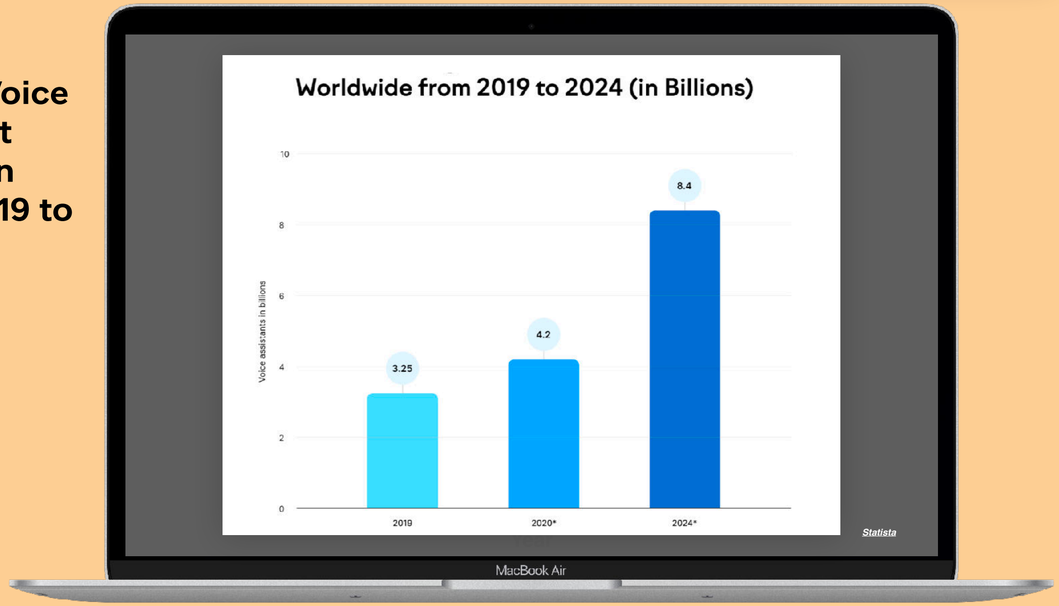
Mercedes-Benz heralds a new era for the user interface with human-like virtual assistant powered by generative AI





Volkswagen brings ChatGPT to its vehicles via voice assist

Digital Voice Assistant Adoption From 2019 to 2024



3.0 The Big Takeaways

Top Takeaways for Discoverability Success in 2025

01

Take stock of AI: internal and external models

What AI tools do your audiences use the most? What tools and processes can your organization leverage to reach them at scale? From paid applications to social media and site properties, optimize your internal processes and external optimizations for the evolving world of search.

02

Evaluate your ecosystem for AI-generated results

As the lines between digital properties blur, how is your brand remaining discoverable with relevant messaging and multimedia? Don't lose sight of the power in local experiences and the connection to digital.

03

Be unique in the competition for engagement

Consumers will likely become overwhelmed, if they haven't already, by the expanse of AI options across platforms with overlapping value competing for their attention. Brands that add unique value to consumer experiences will resonate the most.

04

Use customer data responsibly and to benefit them

AI models will offer brands a breadth of new understanding around consumer behavior. Leverage customer data responsibly to understand needs and the best points of connection in consumer journeys. Customers must feel the value in return for the data they share.

Contact VML to learn more about how to navigate the new search landscape for your brand.

Thank you.

VML

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2025 will be another big year in search.

Contact VML to learn more about how to navigate it for your brand.